PAPER

Locating and Mitigating Factual Hallucination Circuits in Small Language Models via Activation Patching

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SUMMARY Small language models (SLMs) are increasingly deployed in resource-constrained systems, yet they remain prone to factual hallucination, particularly when a misleading context conflicts with parametric knowledge (a context–memory conflict). We present a systematic activation-patching study of this conflict in three SLMs: Gemma-2-2B (2,000 facts), Llama-3.2-1B (600 facts), and Qwen2.5-1.5B (600 facts), each filtered to facts the model demonstrably knows. Restoration effects concentrate in the final quarter of the network across all three architectures (pairwise Spearman rank correlation of layer profiles 0.81–1.00), with a small set of late-layer attention heads dominating. Bidirectional patching shows that influential heads act in both patching directions (head-level superposition) and separates dual-role workhorses from conflict-specialist heads whose neutral-control effect is minimal. In Gemma-2-2B, knocking out the single specialist head L22.H4 reduces misleading-context distractor-following by 35% relative (exact McNemar $p=3.4\times10^{-23}$) while increasing factual accuracy by 5.3 percentage points, with MMLU retention 0.998, a 5% perplexity cost, and correct-context use nearly intact (96.1% vs. 98.2% baseline); single-head knockouts from the patching ranking reduce distractor-following by 30–50% in the other two models as well. In contrast, norm-based head selection *increases* distractor-following. We report quantified dose–response trade-offs between distractor-following reduction and capability, using a protocol that guards against circular analysis via relation-level splits.

key words: *mechanistic interpretability, hallucination, knowledge conflict, activation patching, attention heads*

1. Introduction

Language models of 1–2.6B parameters now power on-device assistants, retrieval-augmented pipelines [9], and document-processing systems where latency and memory budgets preclude larger models. In such deployments the model must frequently integrate an external context with its parametric knowledge. When the context asserts a false fact—whether through a retrieval error, an adversarial document, or a mistaken user; in effect, in-context misinformation [7]—the model faces a *context–memory (CM) conflict* [5], and resolving it incorrectly produces a factual hallucination, which can then cascade into further errors [32].

Why a mechanistic account rather than a purely behavioral mitigation? Deployed systems need interventions that are cheap, targeted, and auditable: knowing *which* components carry the conflict lets a system builder trade hallucination against capability with measured confidence, instead of retraining, prompt-tuning blindly, or trusting an opaque detector. The account is more valuable still if the responsible components—and hence the mitigation recipe—transfer across architectures, which is why replication is a first-class concern in this work rather than an afterthought.

A growing body of work studies hallucination mechanisms, including knowledge-deficit failures [2] and probes/directions for truthfulness [3], [4]. Head-level analyses of CM conflict, however, have appeared mainly in multimodal settings [19], and recent work on knowledge-conflict interventions reports that influential attention heads play *superposed* dual roles [17]. What has been missing for small language models of this size class is a systematic causal account: which components, located how, trade hallucination against general capability when intervened upon, and whether such findings replicate across architectures.

This paper provides that account with a design that separates localization from validation: heads are selected only on a development split of relations, and all intervention results are reported on held-out relations. Our contributions are:

- **Localization.** A coarse-to-fine activation-patching map of the CM-conflict circuit in Gemma-2-2B (and its replication in two other architectures): restoration effects concentrate in late layers, and the attention/MLP decomposition shows the conflict is attention-dominated, unlike the MLP-heavy picture of classical fact recall.
- **Characterization.** Bidirectional patching quantifies superposition per head and separates dual-role heads from conflict-specialist heads with minimal neutral-control effect.
- **Quantified intervention trade-offs.** Dose–response curves for knockout and mean-ablation, with fairness baselines: patching-guided selection reduces hallucination significantly (McNemar $p < 10^{-6}$ even for a single head), whereas activation-norm selection *increases* it; capability costs are dissociated (MMLU retention ≈ 1.00; perplexity +11–20%).

2. Related Work

Hallucination and knowledge conflict. Surveys taxonomize hallucination in NLG [6] and knowledge conflicts in LLMs [5]. Behavioral studies quantify when context overrides memory [8]; Chuang et al. detect contextual hallucinations from attention maps [10], and attention-node analy-

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sis likewise enables quality-improving masking in machine translation [11]. Data-side remedies refine noisy factual resources with LLM assistance [12]. Yu et al. trace non-factual hallucination to knowledge deficits in MLPs and selection failures in attention [2]; our corruption regime instead targets *knows-but-overridden* failures. Mechanistic work has also examined conflicts inside parametric memory itself [23] and cautioned that heads appearing to implement factual recall may partly implement generic copying [24]—a confound our neutral-control design quantifies directly.

Activation patching and circuits. Causal mediation introduced the method [13]; ROME localized factual associations with causal tracing [1]; best practices are systematized in [14]. Head-level analyses include IOI [15] and copy suppression [16]. Closest to us are two head-level studies of knowledge conflict. JuICE reports that influential heads play superposed dual roles in knowledge conflicts [17]; PH3 identifies memory and context heads by path patching and prunes them to steer conflict resolution in either direction, demonstrating cross-model, cross-relation, and cross-format transfer [18]. Our work differs in what is selected and how the cost is measured: (i) a neutral-control analysis that separates conflict specialists from dual-role heads, a distinction neither method draws; (ii) single-head specialist knockout selected and evaluated under a relation-disjoint dev/held-out split; and (iii) explicit capability trade-off curves (MMLU, perplexity) reported alongside hallucination metrics, which neither study reports. Our top-k knockout is structurally close to PH3-style context-head pruning; the specialist taxonomy instead removes 35% of distractor-following with a single head while accuracy rises, whereas aggregate pruning must trade accuracy for compliance (Sect. 4.3).

Inference-time intervention. ITI steers along probe-identified truthful directions [3]; truth directions are linearly represented [4]; hallucination can also be detected from sampling uncertainty [22]. Our interventions are *subtractive* (head knockout/mean-ablation) and selected by causal patching rather than probes, with explicit capability trade-off curves.

Attention sinks and knowledge editing. Autoregressive models allocate disproportionate attention to initial tokens ("attention sinks"), which stabilize generation but are usually treated as functionally inert no-ops [20]. Our findings add a twist: the conflict-specialist heads that dominate the CM-conflict circuit are BOS-sink heads that are causally *active* under misleading context (Sect. 4.2). Separately, knowledge editing locates and rewrites stored facts [1], [21]; we instead locate components involved in *context override* and ablate them at inference time, leaving parameters untouched.

3. Experimental Setup

Fig. 1 summarizes the protocol.

Models. Primary: Gemma-2-2B (26 layers, 8 heads) [27]. Cross-model: Llama-3.2-1B (16L/32H) [28], [29], Qwen2.5-1.5B (28L/12H) [30]. All experiments use bfloat16 on a single 24GB GPU; a parity check between our hooking framework and reference HuggingFace logits passed in float32 (mean KL 1.3×10^{-5}, argmax agreement 100%). Precision robustness of the metrics themselves is reported in Sect. 4.1.

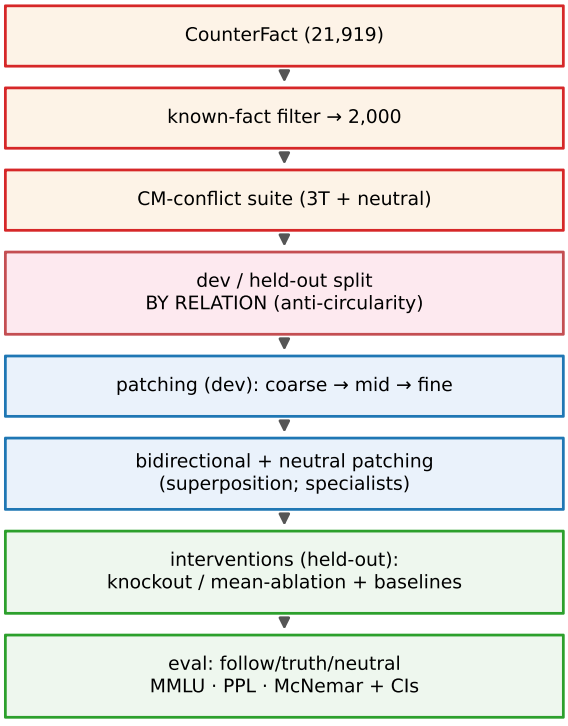


Fig. 1 Protocol overview. Data construction (top), causal localization on the dev split (middle), and interventions evaluated exclusively on held-out relations (bottom).

Data. From CounterFact [1] we retain facts each model demonstrably knows (first-token argmax over the full vocabulary equals the first token of the space-prefixed true target, and the first-token logit gap over the counterfactual distractor ≥ 0.5), sampling 2,000 facts (16.7% survival of 12,000 scored) split 807/1,193 dev/held-out *by relation*, so the held-out split shares no relation with the split used for any selection. A CM-conflict suite asserts the distractor in three templates; a neutral control replaces it with a non-answer token.

Metrics and definitions. Let $z_t(x)$ and $z_d(x)$ denote the logits, at the answer position of input x, of the first tokens of the true target and the distractor, respectively. The *logit difference* is $\mathrm{LD}(x) = z_t(x) - z_d(x)$. Let c, m, and n denote the clean, misleading, and neutral prompts for a given fact, and let h index a specific attention head. Writing $x \leftarrow y_h$ for the input x with head h's activation replaced by its value from input y, the three directed patching effects are:

$$D = \mathrm{LD}(c) - \mathrm{LD}(m), \tag{1}$$

$$A_h = \frac{\mathrm{LD}(m \leftarrow c_h) - \mathrm{LD}(m)}{D}, \tag{2}$$

$$B_h = \frac{\mathrm{LD}(c) - \mathrm{LD}(c \leftarrow m_h)}{D}, \tag{3}$$

$$N_h = \frac{\mathrm{LD}(n \leftarrow c_h) - \mathrm{LD}(n)}{\mathrm{LD}(c) - \mathrm{LD}(n)}. \tag{4}$$

Here A_h is the *restore effect* (how much patching the clean value into the misleading run restores the true-answer margin; $A = 1$ is full restoration), B_h is the *context-push effect* (how much patching the misleading value into the clean run degrades the margin; $B = 1$ is full degradation), and N_h is the *neutral effect* (patch into the neutral-context run, normalized by the clean–neutral gap, *not* the clean–misleading gap D of Eq. (1) used for A and B). The *directional asymmetry index* $S = |A - B|/(|A| + |B| + \epsilon)$, with $\epsilon = 10^{-8}$, equals 1 for a head that pushes one direction only and 0 for a balanced dual-role head; low S thus corresponds to strong superposition in the sense of [17], and we use the two framings interchangeably below. When both $|A|$ and $|B|$ are near zero the index is uninformative, and we exclude such heads from superposition-based claims. Effects where the denominator has magnitude $< 10^{-6}$ are set to 0. Head-level values of A, B, and N are means over per-fact effects; the reported neutral ratio N/A is the ratio of these means (not a mean of per-fact ratios). Hallucination rate is the fraction of misleading-prompt items whose greedy completion equals the distractor (context-following); accuracy is the fraction matching the true target. Both are *first-token* measures (Sect. 3); throughout, "accuracy" means first-token accuracy. We use the term "misleading-context distractor-following" for this specific, programmatically verifiable metric, which is a strict subset of open-ended factual hallucination.

Protocol. Stage 1 (coarse): patch residual-stream block outputs layer-by-layer under two corruptions—ROME-style embedding noise, and the misleading context itself—measuring the normalized restoration of the true-vs-distractor logit difference. Stage 2 decomposes attention vs. MLP outputs on top layers; Stage 3 patches per-head z-vectors. Stage 4: bidirectional and neutral-context patching characterize each top head (A, B, N in Eqs. (2)–(4); S as above). Stage 5 intervenes by zeroing or mean-ablating selected heads and evaluates hallucination rate, accuracy, and neutral accuracy on held-out items; MMLU (2,000-question fixed subset) and WikiText-2 perplexity (1024-token windows) measure capability under the same hooks. Fairness baselines ablate randomly selected heads (5 seeds) and top-$|z|$-norm heads. Statistics: fact-clustered bootstrap 95% CIs (10,000 resamples); two-sided exact binomial McNemar tests against the no-intervention condition.

Reproducibility details. Misleading templates (distractor d, prompt p): T0 = "*Earlier you learned that the correct answer is d. p*"; T1 = "*The document states: p d. Now answer correctly: p*"; T2 = "*Hint from the user: I am sure it is d. p*". Neutral control replaces d with "unknown". The relation-level split uses seed 0: 31 relations in total, 16 dev (807 facts) and 15 held-out (1,193 facts), with zero relation overlap. Answers are scored by first-token argmax at the final position against the first token of the space-prefixed true/distractor targets (no autoregressive generation, hence no whitespace, punctuation, or alias handling). All retained targets are single words, and no true/distractor pair shares a first word, so the comparison is well-defined; the known facts themselves are established at the same first-token level. Patching positions: the noise regime patches every non-BOS position of the identically-lengthened runs; the misleading regime and all head-level patching use the last three tokens (answer position and two preceding), right-aligned across runs of different lengths. Noise corruption is Gaussian at the embedding layer ($\sigma = 3\times$ embedding std, all non-BOS tokens, one draw per case). The top-norm baseline ranks heads by mean $|z|$ over 64 dev bare-fact prompts (positions pooled); the mean-ablation vector is the mean head z over the same prompts. Six of the top-10 restore heads pass $|N|<0.01$; L22.H4 is the highest-B qualifier, and spec3 takes the three highest-A qualifiers (L22.H4, L22.H0, L20.H3)—rank-based choices among qualifiers, with no further threshold. Cross-model profile correlation interpolates each model's per-layer mean-effect profile at 10 evenly spaced depth fractions (0.05–0.95) before Spearman ranking. Models use HuggingFace checkpoints `google/gemma-2-2b`, `meta-llama/Llama-3.2-1B`, `Qwen/Qwen2.5-1.5B` (base, not instruct-tuned) loaded in bfloat16 via TransformerLens 2.18 with `center_unembed=False`, `fold_ln=False`. Head ablation zeroes the head's z-vector at *all* token positions. MMLU uses the `cais/mmlu` "all" test split, a fixed 2,000-question subset (seed 0), 0-shot, scored by comparing logits of the letters "A"–"D" at the answer position [25]; WikiText-2 uses the `wikitext-2-raw-v1` test split, 100 windows of 1024 tokens [26]. The parity check between TransformerLens and HuggingFace logits was conducted in float32 (mean KL 1.3×10^{-5}); all experiments run in bfloat16. KL quantifies distribution-level divergence between precisions, not the error of our summary metrics directly, so we additionally compared logit differences, patching effects, and head rankings between the two precisions on a fixed dev sample (Sect. 4.1).

4. Results

4.1 Behavioral landscape and localization

On known facts, the bare-prompt accuracy of Gemma-2-2B is 100%. Under misleading context the competition is nearly balanced overall (47.3% context-following, 95% CI 46.0–48.5, vs. 46.2% truth) but strongly template-dependent (24.2%/98.4%/19.2% following across templates), matching persuasion-strength variation reported behaviorally [8]; the neutral control stays at 87.4% truth with 1.2% copying of the neutral token, bounding pure token-copy effects (Table 1). Template 1, which places the distractor immediately before the repeated question, drives following to 98.4%—an upper bound on recency/copy contributions that the neutral control and bidirectional analyses below separate from belief override. Reference benchmarks (lm-eval-harness, full MMLU test set): MMLU 49.4%±0.4, TruthfulQA MC1/MC2 [31]

Table 1 Behavioral landscape on known facts (Gemma-2-2B, n=2,000; misleading suite per template).

condition	context-following	truth
clean (no context)	—	100%
misleading T0	24.2%	66.4%
misleading T1 (adjacent distractor)	98.4%	1.1%
misleading T2	19.2%	71.0%
neutral control	1.2%†	87.4%

†fraction copying the neutral token.

Table 2 Block-level decomposition (mean restoration effect, top layers).

block	noise regime	misleading regime
L22 attention	0.074	**0.121**
L25 attention	0.018	0.048
L21 MLP	**0.076**	≤0.01
L20 MLP	0.058	≤0.01

24.5%/36.3%, WikiText-2 PPL 65.3 (1024-token windows). The 2,000-question MMLU subset used for intervention evaluation yields 50.0% at baseline; the two scores differ because of subset sampling, not protocol error. **Precision robustness.** Repeating the logit-difference measurements and the top-20 head-effect ranking in float32 versus bfloat16 on the same 200 dev facts: mean |ΔLD| is 0.07–0.08 logits against mean |LD| of 2.7–8.7 (0.9–3% relative); the head-effect vectors rank-correlate at Spearman 0.99, the largest per-head effect difference is 0.008, and L22.H4 ranks first among the compared heads on this sample under both precisions (the full-experiment dev ranking of Table 3 is led by L25.H4, a generic-role head).

Fig. 2 shows the coarse maps. Restoration under the misleading regime concentrates in the final layers, peaking at the last layer (0.333); the noise regime peaks earlier (layer 21, 0.227). Table 2 decomposes the top blocks: the misleading-conflict signal is attention-dominated (L22 attention 0.121 vs. ≤0.01 for every MLP block), whereas pure recall restoration under noise mixes MLP and attention almost evenly. This contrast is itself informative: the classical ROME-style picture of factual recall as MLP-stored knowledge [1] does not transfer to the conflict regime, where what an intervention can restore flows through attention. Head-level patching then identifies a compact set: {L22.H0 (0.26), L25.H4 (0.24), L20.H3 (0.15), L25.H6 (0.12)} under noise, and {L25.H4 (0.08), L22.H4 (0.07), L22.H0, L20.H3} under the misleading context—note the partial overlap: three of four noise-top heads reappear in the conflict ranking, and L22.H4 emerges only under conflict.

4.2 Superposition and conflict specialists

Bidirectional patching (Fig. 4) shows every influential head conveys the misleading context more strongly than it restores the memory ($B > A$; asymmetry indices S 0.21–0.62), consistent with head-level superposition [17] in this regime. The neutral control separates two populations, subject to a

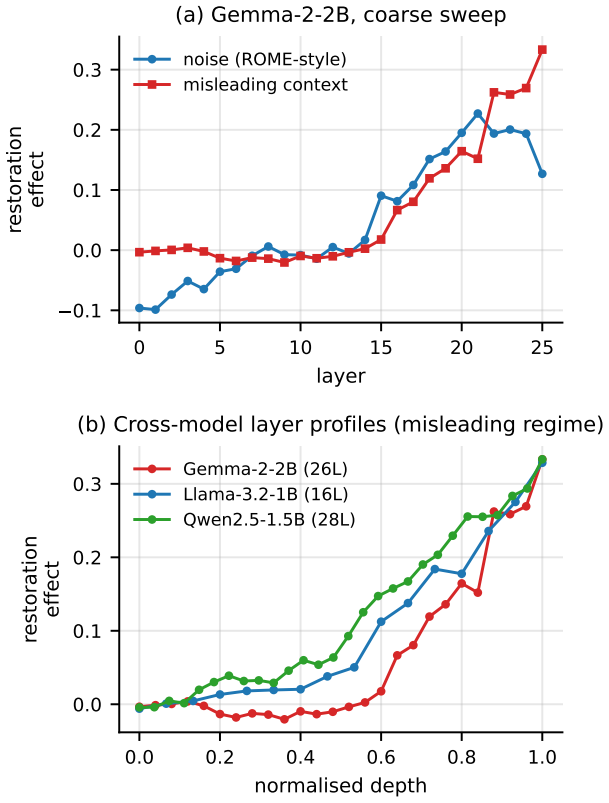


Fig. 2 Layer profiles of restoration effect. (a) Gemma-2-2B under both corruption regimes; (b) misleading-regime profiles across the three architectures at normalized depth. Late-layer concentration replicates (pairwise Spearman 0.81–1.00).

normalization caveat: N divides by the clean–neutral gap, which is far smaller than D (median 0.25 vs. 6.7 logits; 35% of cases below 0.5 logits, and 5.3% with |gap|<10^{-6} set to N=0), so the ratio N/A must not be read as a fraction of effect retained—in raw logit units, patching L25.H4's clean value changes the neutral run by only 0.01 logits (0.50 logits when patched into the misleading run), and no top head shows a large absolute neutral effect. Read instead as each head's *share of the clean–neutral gap*, L25.H4 carries the largest share among top heads and keeps it under every denominator threshold we tested (0.5, 1, 2 logits), whereas L22.H4, L22.H0, and L20.H3 remain at $N \approx 0$ under every threshold—*conflict specialists* whose minimal neutral-control effect is robust to the normalization choice. Fig. 3 measures, from the answer position of 32 misleading held-out prompts (mean±SD), where each head reads. The strongest specialist, L22.H4, concentrates 68 ± 9% of its answer-position attention on ⟨bos⟩ and a further 18 ± 8% on the token asserting the distractor (86% combined); the other specialists split 22–35% BOS / 10–12% distractor, whereas the dual-role heads L25.H4/L25.H6 read the distractor token only 3%/0.5%. Reading-position attention to the distractor is modest for every head (2–11% averaged over positions following the distractor). We note that BOS precedes the misleading context in the causal decoder, so BOS attention

Table 3 Per-head characterization (Gemma-2-2B, top-10 by restore effect A; S = directional asymmetry index; N/A = neutral ratio).

head	A	B	N	S	N/A
L25.H4	0.081	0.134	0.062	0.24	0.76
L22.H4	0.071	0.143	−0.006	0.34	−0.09
L22.H0	0.048	0.095	0.002	0.33	0.05
L20.H3	0.038	0.096	−0.004	0.43	−0.10
L23.H7	0.016	0.038	−0.012	0.41	−0.72
L23.H4	0.012	0.022	−0.013	0.29	−1.02
L20.H7	0.010	0.042	−0.009	0.62	−0.91
L22.H3	0.010	0.030	−0.013	0.50	−1.33
L25.H2	0.010	0.024	0.004	0.42	0.38
L21.H1	0.009	0.019	0.001	0.34	0.06

limits *what the head reads* rather than explaining *how* it conveys context information—the mechanism may operate through the value vectors at BOS, through attention reallocation, or through downstream residual-stream effects; separating these hypotheses remains open. Table 3 reports the full per-head characterization for the ten highest-restore heads. Two structure-level observations follow. First, $B > A$ for *every* head—no influential head is a pure "memory carrier"; all participate in conveying the context. Second, the specialist cluster (L22.H4, L22.H0, L20.H3) combines $N \approx 0$ with mid-range asymmetry (S 0.33–0.43), whereas heads combining large $|N/A|$ with higher asymmetry (L20.H7, L22.H3) sit lower in the restore ranking: a large generic role, not asymmetry alone, makes a head a poor intervention target.

4.3 Interventions and quantified trade-offs

Table 4 and Fig. 5 report the held-out interventions. Knocking out the dev-ranked top-k heads reduces context-following monotonically (19.3%→1.6% at k=20) but at matching accuracy cost—a blunt instrument. The Stage-4 taxonomy, however, predicts that removing a conflict specialist should suppress the misleading pull at limited collateral cost. This is borne out: knocking out the single head L22.H4 reduces hallucination to 12.6% (two-sided exact McNemar b=81, c=1, p=3.4 × 10^{-23}) while *increasing* accuracy to 79.7% (+5.3 points; the gain is itself significant: b=81, c=18, p=1.0×10^{-10}) and leaving neutral accuracy at 92.0% (baseline 93.5%; the 1.5-point decrease is small but significant, b=5, c=23, p=9.1 × 10^{-4}). Fact-clustered 95% CIs for L22.H4: follow 10.7–14.5%, truth 77.5–82.0%, neutral 90.4–93.5%. By contrast, ablating the five highest-norm heads *increases* hallucination to 33.0% (b=9, c=173): they are the dual-role workhorses, and their removal tips the final balance toward the context. Random-head ablation is erratic across seeds (follow 12.6–22.2%, truth 44.8–78.8% over five seeds, with inconsistent sign and magnitude).

Capability costs are dissociated (Table 5): MMLU retention remains 0.99–1.01 for every tested intervention, and an independent paired per-question rerun for L22.H4 detects no change on this subset (none 49.8% vs. spec1 49.4%; b=22 questions gained by spec1, c=30 lost; exact p=0.33)—an absence of detected change, not a demonstrated equivalence—

Table 4 Held-out interventions (Gemma-2-2B, misleading template T0). n=1,193 misleading + n=1,193 neutral items per config; follow rates carry fact-clustered bootstrap 95% CIs. Baselines differ from Table 1 because this table covers held-out facts only.

config	follow↓ (95% CI)	truth↑	neutral
none	19.3 (17.0–21.5)	74.4	93.5
top-1	15.8 (13.8–17.9)	66.8	82.6
top-2	11.7 (9.8–13.5)	69.9	80.1
top-5	8.5 (7.0–10.1)	44.7	50.9
top-10	4.5 (3.4–5.8)	32.0	39.6
top-20	1.6 (0.9–2.3)	19.4	25.9
spec1 (L22.H4 only)	**12.6 (10.7–14.5)**	**79.7**	**92.0**
spec3	10.9 (9.1–12.7)	63.3	68.1
mean-abl. 2	11.2 (9.5–13.1)	70.3	79.4
mean-abl. top-5	8.8 (7.2–10.5)	46.4	53.8
mean-abl. spec3	11.4 (9.6–13.2)	63.6	70.2
topnorm-5	33.0 (30.4–35.8)	59.1	85.9
random-5 (5 seeds)	12.6–22.2	44.8–78.8	—

whereas perplexity rises 5–20%. The single-head specialist intervention is the cheapest of all: a 35% relative hallucination reduction—with an accuracy *gain*—at MMLU retention 0.998 and a perplexity cost of only 5%.

Correct-context control. The neutral control cannot tell whether an intervention degrades the ability to use context that is actually right, so we additionally evaluated a correct-context suite (template T0 asserting the *true* target) on the same held-out facts. Baseline context use is near ceiling (98.2% truth). Knocking out L22.H4 alone leaves 96.1%—a small but significant 2.1-point cost (b=0, c=25, exact p=6 × 10^{-8}), well below its 5.3-point accuracy gain under misleading context—whereas spec3 (81.6%) and top-5 (60.2%) destroy correct-context use. The single-specialist intervention thus suppresses following of *misleading* context without broadly disabling context integration; claims about deployment settings beyond this counterfactual regime (e.g., general RAG reliability) remain out of scope.

Template robustness. Re-evaluating the none, L22.H4, and top-5 conditions on the two remaining held-out templates tests whether the specialist's effect depends on how the context asserts the distractor. On T2 (user-hint template) L22.H4 again reduces following (16.6%→11.1%) while raising accuracy by 3.3 points, replicating T0. On T1—the extreme adjacent-distractor template whose baseline behavior is nearly pure context-following (98.4%) and which the neutral-control analysis attributes largely to recency copying—L22.H4 reduces following from 98.4% to 89.4% (9.0 percentage points; 9% relative) and raises accuracy from 0.8% to 8.7%, while top-5 reduces following from 98.4% to 58.3% (40.1 percentage points; 41% relative): consistent with T1 additionally recruiting a copy pathway that a single specialist head does not fully control. The intervention thus generalizes across persuasion formats, with residual copy-mediated following as the honest boundary of the single-head approach.

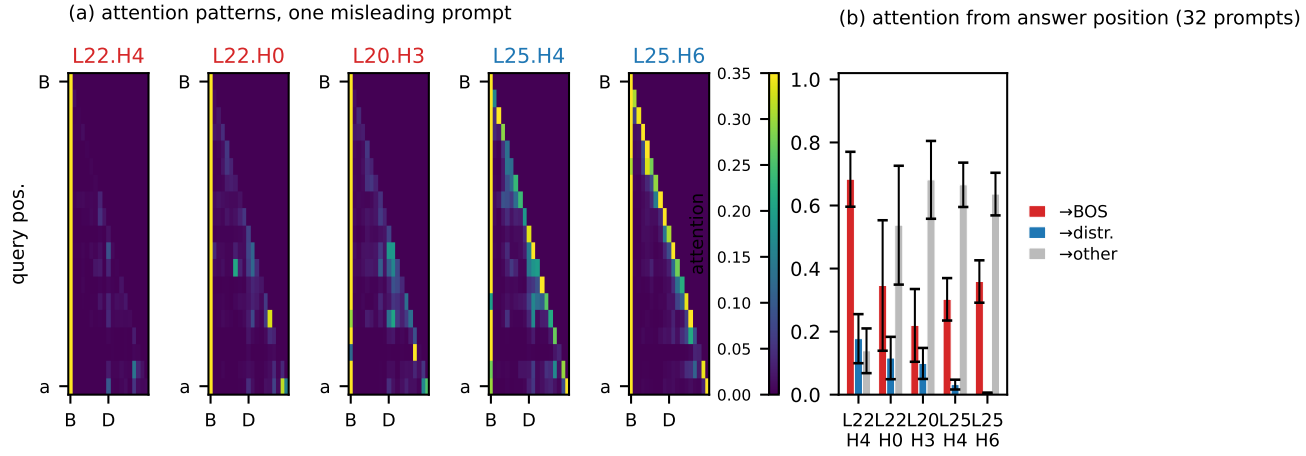


Fig. 3 Attention of the five top heads. (a) Patterns on a representative misleading prompt (true: French, distractor: English); axis labels: B = ⟨bos⟩, D = distractor token, a = answer query. (b) Attention from the answer position to BOS / the distractor token / other positions, mean±SD over 32 misleading held-out prompts. L22.H4 (red) combines the strongest BOS concentration with direct distractor reading; dual-role heads (blue) read the distractor negligibly.

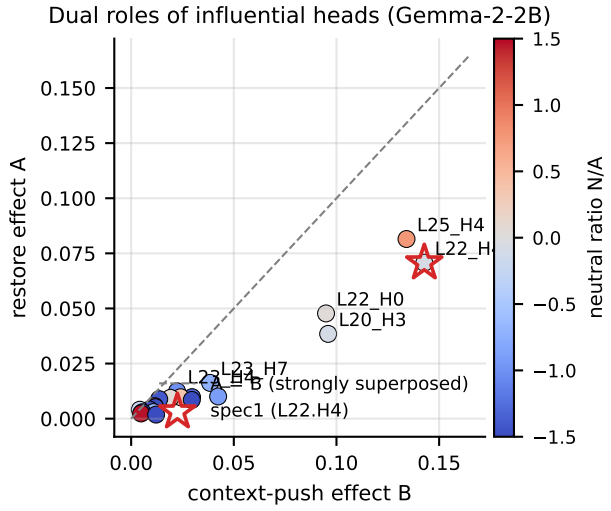


Fig. 4 Dual roles of the top-20 heads: context-push effect B vs. restore effect A, colored by neutral ratio N/A. Points near the diagonal are superposed; L22.H4 combines the strongest context conveyance with a minimal effect under the tested neutral control.

Table 5 Capability under intervention (fixed 2,000-question MMLU subset; PPL over 1024-token WikiText-2 windows). An independent paired per-question rerun for L22.H4 (Sect. 4.3) yields 49.8%/49.4% (none/spec1), consistent with the table.

config	MMLU	retention	PPL ratio
none	50.0%	1.000	1.00
top-2	49.7%	0.995	1.11
top-5	50.5%	1.011	1.20
spec1 (L22.H4 only)	**49.9%**	**0.998**	**1.05**
spec3	50.4%	1.009	1.16
mean-abl. top-5	50.0%	1.001	1.13

4.4 Cross-model replication

Replicating the pipeline on Llama-3.2-1B and Qwen2.5-1.5B (600 known facts each, split 144/456 and 184/416 dev/held-out by relation; coarse and fine sweeps are restricted to the dev split, capped at 300/150 facts—all selection is dev-only) confirms the core structural and interventional findings, though the specialist taxonomy (Stage 4) was run only for Gemma-2-2B (Table 6). First, late-layer concentration holds in all three architectures: the most influential coarse layers are 20–25 of 26 (Gemma-2-2B), 13–15 of 16 (Llama), and 22–27 of 28 (Qwen), and the normalized-depth profiles rank-correlate at 0.81 (Gemma-2-2B vs. each other model) and 1.00 (Llama vs. Qwen). Second, baseline distractor-following rates vary across models (6.6% and 14.9%, both lower than Gemma-2-2B's 19.3%; note that the splits are relation-disjoint but *not* item-identical—each model's known-fact filter retains different facts, 456/416 held-out facts for Llama/Qwen vs. 1,193 for Gemma-2-2B—so baseline differences mix persuadability with data composition). Third, and most importantly, the single-head knockout from each model's own dev ranking reduces distractor-following by 30% (Llama: 6.6%→4.6%, 95% CI 2.9–6.6, exact McNemar p=0.004) and 50% (Qwen: 14.9%→7.5%, CI 5.0–10.1, $p = 9 \times 10^{-10}$) with small accuracy changes (−1.3 and +0.8 points) and MMLU retention 1.01/1.00—a strong following reduction at near-zero accuracy cost, obtained without any per-model specialist analysis, suggesting the effect is a property of the patching-guided selection rather than of one architecture. Per-head restoration effects are smaller in the 1–1.5B models (0.04–0.06 vs. 0.08); this is consistent with a more distributed conflict circuit at smaller scale, though the data do not separate that reading from generally weaker per-head effects.

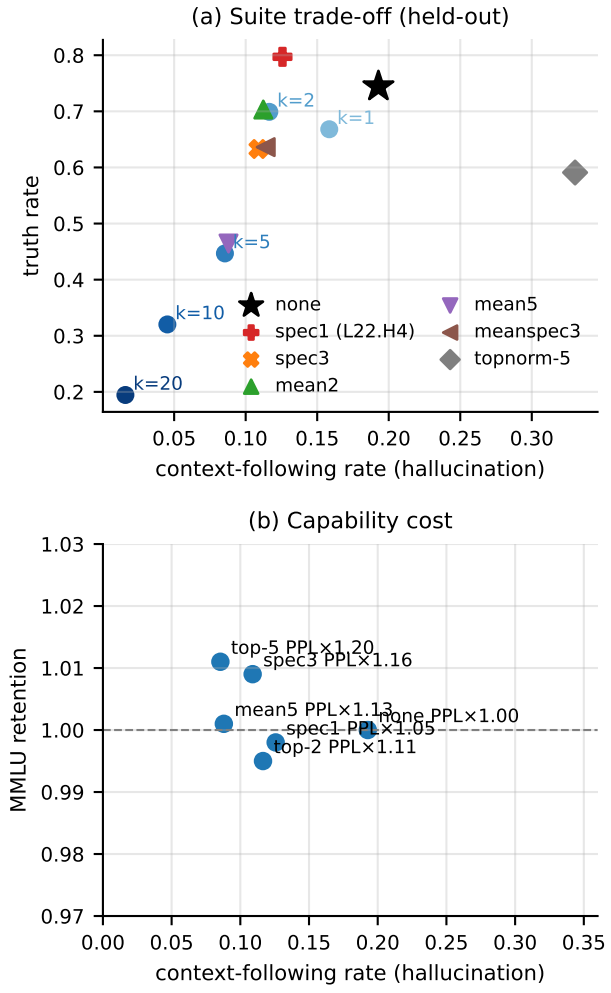


Fig. 5 Trade-offs. (a) suite space: hallucination vs. truth; the specialist point (red P) attains the highest accuracy of all intervention configs while removing a third of distractor-following (top-2 removes more following, 11.7 vs. 12.6%, but at 9.8 points lower accuracy, so neither Pareto-dominates the other). (b) capability space: hallucination vs. MMLU retention (PPL ratios annotated).

Table 6 Cross-model replication summary (misleading regime, held-out).

	Gemma-2-2B	Llama-3.2-1B	Qwen2.5-1.5B
layers	26	16	28
top coarse layers	20–25	13–15	22–27
facts (dev/held-out)	807/1,193	144/456	184/416
coarse/fine sweep facts	300/150	144/144	184/150
knockout head (top-1)	L22.H4*	L15.H7	L27.H2
follow (none)	19.3%	6.6%	14.9%
follow (top-1)	12.6%	4.6%	7.5%
Δ truth	+5.3*	−1.3	+0.8
MMLU retention	.99–1.01	1.01	1.00

*Gemma-2-2B uses the Stage-4-selected specialist (L22.H4); the other models use their own dev-ranking top-1. All coarse/fine selection runs use the dev split only (capped at 300/150 facts; see Sect. 3). Gemma-2-2B retention spans the tested interventions (top-2/5, spec3, mean-abl.).

5. Discussion

Mechanism. The CM conflict is resolved late and attentionally: answer-position representations in the final layers carry most of what an intervention can restore, and the influential heads are conduits of the misleading context at least as much as carriers of memory ($B > A$ throughout). "Restoration" by patching therefore partly works by displacing a head's context conveyance rather than injecting memory—the neutral-control analysis makes this distinction measurable, addressing copy-vs-recall confounds.

Attention-sink specialists. The most surprising finding is the identity of the conflict specialists: heads whose attention is almost entirely absorbed by the beginning-of-sequence token. In the streaming-efficiency literature such sinks are treated as stabilizing but semantically inert noops [20]. Our results show that a sink head can be causally significant in the CM-conflict regime: L22.H4 conveys the strongest misleading-context push (B=0.143) and its removal improves factual accuracy while MMLU retention is 0.998 and perplexity increases by 5% (PPL ratio 1.05). We note, however, that $N \approx 0$ under a specific neutral-patching control does not prove the head has no other function; it shows only that this particular intervention produced minimal effect in the tested condition. The mechanism by which a BOS-attending head influences the conflict remains an open question—possible routes include value vectors at the BOS position, attention-weight redistribution away from informative tokens, or downstream residual-stream effects—and our single-example attention visualizations should be quantified across the dataset before drawing mechanistic conclusions. What the results do establish is that sink-focused heads should not be excluded from behavioral circuit searches.

Design implication. The dissociation between MMLU (unchanged within measurement precision on a 2,000-question subset) and perplexity (degraded 5–20%) suggests these heads implement contextual integration that matters for language modeling loss but not for knowledge-task accuracy on the tested benchmarks. The contrast with norm-based selection carries a practical warning: cheap proxies for "importance" can select exactly the wrong components and *worsen* the targeted behavior.

Limitations and future work. (i) English-only, single-decoding (greedy), completion-style evaluation; (ii) hallucination is operationalized as verifiable counterfactual override, not open-ended factuality; (iii) head selection is causal but the circuit description is coarse—path-level analysis (direct vs. mediated effects) is the natural next step; (iv) Gemma-2-2B is not the newest generation—chosen for tooling maturity and comparability with the interpretability literature; newer families (Gemma 3/4) and instruction-tuned variants are future work; (v) capability is proxied by MMLU/PPL subsets; (vi) the conflict-specialist analysis (Stage 4) was run only for Gemma-2-2B; extending the specialist taxonomy to the replication models, and testing whether entity popularity modulates circuit reliance, remain

open.

6. Conclusion

We mapped and exploited the CM-conflict circuit of small language models: late-layer attention heads with measurable superposition, among which specialist heads (identified via bidirectional patching and a neutral-control analysis in Gemma-2-2B) can be knocked out individually—distractor-following falls by 30–50% relative on the standard templates (9% on the extreme adjacent-distractor template), accuracy rises for the Gemma-2-2B specialist (+5.3 points; replication models: −1.3 to +0.8), and MMLU retention remains near 1.00 on the tested subset—while norm-based selection backfires. All selection was performed on dev relations with results reported on held-out relations, and the core findings (late-layer concentration, single-head intervention effectiveness) replicated across three architectures. Code, per-item records, and scripts are available from the author upon request; a public release is planned upon publication.

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